DECK & DOMINION

A Cooperative Deckbuilding TTRPG

Player's Rulebook

Beta v1.0

What Is This Game?

Deck & Dominion is a tabletop roleplaying game where all conflict is resolved through card games. Not as an abstraction. The cards are real. Within the world of Deck & Dominion, decks are possessions, rare pulls are treasure, and disputes between nations are settled across the table.

You play two games at once. Outside of combat, you play a traditional tabletop RPG. You explore the world, navigate political intrigue, build relationships, and make choices that shape the story. Your Dungeon Master controls the setting, the characters you meet, and the consequences of your decisions.

When conflict erupts, you pull out your deck. Combat is a cooperative card game where the entire party plays together on a shared board against the DM's encounter deck. Your creatures, spells, and equipment are real within the fiction. The cards in your hand are the tools your character actually carries.

Your deck is your character sheet. How you build it, what you collect, and what you choose to include defines who your character is and how they fight. Two players of the same class with different cards play completely different games.

The World Runs on Cards

The gods enforce this. Cards are the medium through which power flows in this world. Every civilization, every culture, every conflict bows to the same system. Armies don't clash with swords and shields alone. They duel with decks.

This means the world is shaped by cards the same way ours is shaped by economics. Card shops exist in every town. Collectors hoard rare pulls behind locked vaults. Black markets trade in banned cards. Tournaments are social events where reputations are built and destroyed. A character's deck is their identity, their livelihood, and their weapon all at once.

Booster packs appear in the wild as divine artifacts, scattered by the gods themselves. Dungeon delving isn't just about gold. It's about cracking packs in forgotten ruins and hoping for something that reshapes your strategy. The thrill of pulling a rare card from a pack found in a dragon's hoard is the thrill of finding a magic sword in any other RPG, except you shuffled it into your deck and used it to win the next fight.

The Classes

Every player chooses a class at character creation. Your class determines your mechanical identity: the types of cards you play, the role you fill on the team, and the strategies available to you. Each class owns a specific piece of the game's mechanical space, and without that class present, the party cannot access it.

This matters. A party without a Sorcerer cannot interact with the graveyard. A party without a Crafter will struggle with mana. Every class is essential, and every player at the table knows their role is irreplaceable. Choose wisely, and choose together.

Within each class, three archetypes offer different approaches to the same role. Your archetype is your playstyle. You can build decks for any archetype within your class, and you can switch which deck you bring to each session, but you must build it from the cards you've collected.

COMMANDER

The one who makes everyone else better.

The Commander doesn't win fights alone. The Commander wins fights by making every other player at the table more effective than they have any right to be. Your creatures are modest. Your spells are simple. But when you play a card, the entire board changes. A creature that was going to trade evenly now survives. An attack that would have fallen short now kills. The Commander's power is invisible until you remove it, and then everything falls apart.

If you want to be the reason the plan worked, play Commander.

Marshal

Board-wide buffs, anthems, and army coordination. The Marshal makes every creature on the board hit harder and survive longer. Your cards say things like "all friendly creatures get +1 attack." Individually small. Collectively devastating. The Marshal wants a wide board full of creatures to buff, and rewards the party for going wide. You are the tide that lifts all ships.

Tactician

Extra attacks, deck peeking, and action manipulation. The Tactician controls the flow of battle itself. You see the DM's hand. You reorder their deck. You give your teammates extra attacks and extra plays. The Tactician doesn't make creatures stronger. The Tactician gives the party more actions than the rules say they should have. Information dominance and action economy are your weapons.

Warden

Shields, heals, and tower creatures. The Warden keeps the party alive when everything goes wrong. You build towers that heal, absorb damage, and protect creatures from death. Your game is defense, attrition, and making the DM regret every attack. The party might not thank you for the turns where nothing died, but they'll notice the turn you're not there.

WIZARD

The combo engine. The answer to everything.

The Wizard owns spells, and spells are the most flexible tool in the game. Counterspells that deny the DM's best plays. Enchantments that turn a weak creature into a monster. Illusions that duplicate the best thing on the board. The Wizard's cards don't do one thing. They amplify, deny, copy, and warp everything around them.

The Wizard is the class with the highest skill ceiling. Playing it well means reading the board, holding cards for the perfect moment, and knowing when to say no. If you want to be the player who always has the answer, play Wizard.

Enchanter

Keywords and keyword tricks. The Enchanter changes how creatures fight, not how hard they hit. Deathtouch on a token. First Strike on a defender. Lifelink on your biggest threat. Your cards are temporary, lasting only a turn, which means your gameplay is about timing. The right keyword at the right moment is worth more than any stat buff. You are the reason the DM can never trust their combat math.

Illusionist

Cloning, copying, and multiplication. The Illusionist creates things that shouldn't exist. Copy the best creature on the board. Duplicate an ally's threat. Flood the field with phantom images that the DM has to deal with even though they're not real. The Illusionist's power scales with the quality of what's already in play. The better the board, the better your copies.

Abjurer

Denial, counterspells, and protection. The Abjurer says no. The DM plays their best card, and you negate it. They target your strongest creature, and you redirect it. They think they're winning, and you erase their last play from existence. The Abjurer is reactive by nature, but in a game where the DM is always trying to kill you, reactive is powerful.

SORCERER

The graveyard belongs to you. All of it.

The Sorcerer owns the graveyard. Not just their own cards. Everything that dies, everything that's discarded, every card that hits the shared graveyard is the Sorcerer's resource. In a game where creatures die constantly, spells are spent every turn, and equipment breaks, the graveyard is the largest resource pool on the table. The Sorcerer is the only class that can touch it.

Without a Sorcerer, dead cards are gone forever. With one, death is just a temporary inconvenience. If you want to turn the graveyard into your personal toolbox, play Sorcerer.

Necromancer

Resurrects creatures from the graveyard. The dead serve again. Your teammates' creatures die in combat, and you bring them back. Cheaply at first, with restrictions on what you can return. As your collection grows, those restrictions disappear. By late game, nothing the DM kills stays dead. The Necromancer turns every loss into a delay, and every delay into inevitability.

Dark Ritualist

Sacrifice for power. The Ritualist doesn't wait for things to die. The Ritualist kills their own team's creatures on purpose because the payoff is worth more than the body. Sacrifice a token, draw three cards. Sacrifice two creatures, deal massive damage. The Ritualist is a resource conversion engine that turns disposable creatures into mana, cards, and damage. You need a teammate who generates fodder, and then you become unstoppable.

Hexer

Exile cards from the graveyard to debuff enemies. The Hexer turns the dead into weapons against the living. Every card you exile fuels a curse, a stat reduction, or a crippling debuff on the DM's creatures. The graveyard is your ammunition.

DPS

You kill things. That's the job.

The DPS is the party's source of creatures and direct damage. While the Commander buffs the board, the Wizard manipulates spells, the Sorcerer recycles the dead, and the Crafter generates resources, the DPS is the one actually putting threats on the table and pointing them at the enemy. Your cards are creatures, burn spells, and more creatures.

Every party needs someone whose turn involves playing something with attack and health and sending it at the DM's face. That's you. If you want to be the one dealing the damage that actually wins the fight, play DPS.

Swarm

Cheap creatures, wide boards, quantity over quality. The Swarm floods the field with disposable bodies. Goblins that draw cards when they die. Ants that get stronger with every additional Ant. Spiders that generate tokens every turn. Your creatures are individually weak but collectively overwhelming. The DM can't kill them fast enough, and every body on the board is another target for the Commander's buffs, the Enchanter's keywords, or the Blacksmith's equipment.

Big

Expensive creatures, massive stats, quality over quantity. The Big archetype plays one creature and makes it the scariest thing on the board. Ogres with raw stats. Golems with shields and resilience. Wurms with trample. And at the top end, Kaiju and Dragons that make the DM reconsider their life choices. You need mana to play these things, and you need protection to keep them alive, but when they stick, nothing the DM has can stand up to them.

Undead

Fodder that benefits from death. Graveyard count matters. Your creatures are mediocre on their own but scale off how many things have died. Zombies that refuse to leave the board. Vampires that heal the party with every attack. Skeletons that get stronger as the graveyard fills. And at the highest rarity, Death Knights that hold multiple pieces of equipment, turning each one into a walking arsenal. The longer the fight goes, the stronger you get.

CRAFTER

You build the engine that makes everything run.

The Crafter owns equipment, mana generation, and artifacts. In a game where every card costs mana and every creature is better with gear, the Crafter is the player who makes everyone else's turns possible. Without a Crafter, the party's mana economy is limited to basic land drops. With one, the team has the fuel to play their best cards when they need them.

The Crafter is the least glamorous class and the most essential. If you want to be the foundation the entire party is built on, play Crafter.

Farmer

Plant creatures and mana generation. The Farmer grows things that produce mana every turn. Sunflowers, ancient oaks, jungle vines. Your board is a garden of mana-generating creatures that fuel the entire party's shared pool. The Farmer's game is sustained acceleration. Every turn your plants survive, the party gets further ahead on resources. You don't deal damage. You make it possible for everyone else to deal more.

Blacksmith

Equipment and permanent stat buffs. The Blacksmith arms the party. Swords, armor, shields, and at higher rarities, dwarven masterwork, elven enchanted blades, and cursed daedric gear. Equipment is permanent, which means every piece you play is an investment that stays on the board. The Blacksmith's game is building one or two creatures into unkillable, over-equipped monsters.

Alchemist

Consumables, potions, and cheap burst effects. The Alchemist provides immediate tactical advantage through single-use effects. Attack potions, healing draughts, defensive elixirs, and at higher rarities, transmutation and volatile experimental concoctions. Your cards are cheap and powerful but gone after one use. The Alchemist's game is having the right potion at the right moment.

Basic Rules

Shared Resources

Deck & Dominion is a cooperative card game. The entire party shares a single board, a single health pool, a single mana pool, and a single graveyard. When a creature enters play, it exists on the shared board regardless of who played it. When the party takes damage, it comes from the shared health total. When a card is spent, it goes to the shared graveyard.

This means every decision affects everyone. The Crafter's mana fuels the Wizard's counterspells. The DPS's dead creatures become the Sorcerer's resurrection targets. The Commander's buffs apply to every creature on the board. You are one team playing one game.

Resource	Description
HP Pool	One shared health total for the entire party. 8 HP per player.
Mana Pool	All players' lands and mana-generating effects contribute to one shared pool.
Board	One shared board. All players' creatures exist together.
Graveyard	One shared graveyard for all discards, spent spells, and dead creatures.

Party HP

The party shares a single HP pool equal to 8 HP per player. If the shared HP reaches zero, the party loses the encounter.

Party Size	Shared HP
3 players	24 HP
4 players	32 HP
5 players	40 HP
6 players	48 HP

DM HP

The DM's HP is scaled per encounter based on difficulty. The DM's total HP equals the HP-per-player value multiplied by the number of players.

Difficulty	HP per Player	Example (5 Players)
Tutorial	6	30 HP
Easy	8	40 HP
Medium	10	50 HP
Hard	12	60 HP
Boss	15+	75+ HP

Decks

Each player builds and brings their own deck to each session. Deck size has a minimum of 30 cards and a maximum of 60 cards. Smaller decks are more consistent. Every card above 30 reduces how often you see your best cards. The game will teach you this naturally.

You draw an opening hand of 5 cards at the start of each encounter. Your maximum hand size is 8 cards. If you are at 8 cards at the start of your turn, you may choose to draw and then discard one card to the graveyard, or choose not to draw and keep your hand as it is.

Mana

All cards cost mana to play. Mana comes from lands and mana-generating creatures and spells. All mana goes into the shared pool, and any player can spend from it on their turn.

Rule	Description
Tap Mechanic	Lands and mana creatures tap to produce mana. They untap at the start of their owner's turn.
Creature Mana	Creatures that generate mana also tap, just like lands.
Burst Mana	Mana from spells disappears at end of turn if unspent.
Persistence	Mana from tapped lands and creatures remains in the pool until spent.

Turn Structure

Players choose their own turn order each round. After all players have taken a turn, the DM takes their turn.

Player Turn Phases

1. Draw Draw a card from your deck. If you are at maximum hand size (8), you may choose to draw and discard one card, or skip your draw.

2. Mana Untap your lands and mana creatures. Gain mana from any sources that generate it at the start of your turn.

3. Play Play any number of cards you can afford from your hand. Creatures, spells, equipment, persistents, towers — anything.

4. Attack Choose which of your creatures attack and what they target. Creatures can attack enemy creatures or the DM's HP directly.

5. Resolution Resolve all combat damage and triggered effects.

6. End Your turn ends. Pass to a teammate of your choice.

A player may choose to do nothing and pass their turn. Players can hold unspent mana to play reaction cards during the DM's turn. Only one reaction card may be played per trigger.

Mulligan: Players may mulligan up to two times after their initial first draw. You must take the 2nd redraw if you use both mulligans

Deckout: There are no loss conditions related to decking out. You simply stop drawing cards, which means you no longer have cards to play. You're likely to reach zero HP if you can no longer play the game.

The DM's Turn

The DM plays after all players have finished their turns. The DM draws cards equal to the number of players and may play lands equal to the number of players. All other rules are the same as player turns: tap lands for mana, play cards, attack with creatures.

The DM builds custom encounter decks before each session using the same card list as the players, but without the one per class restriction. A Necromancer's tower fight could have all 3 Sorcerer archetypes in one deck. The recommended minimum deck size for the DM is 100 cards to avoid decking out.

Combat

Combat uses Hearthstone-style targeting. The attacker chooses their target: either an enemy creature or the opponent's HP directly. There is no declare blockers phase. Instead, creatures with the Taunt keyword force the attacker to target them before anything else.

When two creatures fight, they deal damage to each other simultaneously. Damage is permanent until healed. A creature that takes damage equal to or exceeding its health is destroyed and sent to the graveyard. Creatures with First Strike deal their damage before the defender strikes back. If the First Strike creature kills the defender, it takes no damage.

Win and Lose Conditions

Win conditions vary by encounter. The most common is reducing the DM's HP to zero. Some encounters require surviving a set number of rounds, decking out the opponent, or completing a specific objective. The DM sets the stakes before combat begins.

The party loses if their shared HP reaches zero.

Keywords

Keywords are abilities that appear on creature cards, equipment, and spells. They follow consistent rules regardless of where they appear.

Combat Keywords

Keyword	Effect
Haste	This creature may attack twice this turn.
Trample	Excess damage beyond what is needed to kill a creature hits the opponent's HP.
Deathtouch	Kills any creature it damages, regardless of remaining health.
Lifelink	Damage dealt by this creature restores player HP by the same amount.
First Strike	Deals its damage before the defender. If it kills the defender, it takes no damage back.
Taunt	Must be targeted before other creatures. Attacks cannot bypass a Taunt creature.
Poison X	Deals X damage to this creature at the end of its owner's turn for 3 rounds.

Card Type Keywords

Keyword	Effect
Persistent	Stays on the board until destroyed. Has health and can be targeted like a creature.
Tower	A persistent with 0 attack. Cannot attack. Must be destroyed to remove.
Equipment	Attaches to a creature. One equipment per creature unless otherwise stated. Destroyed when the creature dies.
Shield X	Absorbs X damage before health is affected. Does not regenerate unless stated.

Party Composition

Each player must choose a unique class. No two players may share a class unless the party size exceeds five, in which case one class may be doubled.

Party Size	Composition
3 players	Missing 2 classes. Real weaknesses. Plan around them.
4 players	Missing 1 class. A noticeable gap. Choose what you can live without.
5 players	Full coverage. Every mechanical space is represented.
6 players	One class doubled. That role is strong.

Party composition is a strategic decision. A party without a Sorcerer cannot interact with the graveyard at all. A party without a Crafter is limited to basic land drops for mana. A party without a Commander has no board-wide buffs or turn manipulation. These gaps are real and meaningful. Discuss your composition as a group before the campaign begins.

Within your class, you can build decks for any archetype you have cards for and switch between sessions. Your class is your identity. Your archetype is your loadout. Commit to a class, experiment with archetypes.

Finding Cards

You start with a pre-built 30-card starter deck based on your chosen class and archetype. Everything after that is earned through play.

Cards enter your collection primarily through randomized booster packs found as loot during adventures. The gods scatter packs throughout the world as divine artifacts. Cracking a pack in a dungeon, a ruined temple, or a conquered stronghold is how your collection grows. What you pull is random. What you do with it is strategy.

Individual cards can also be purchased from shops in towns and cities at a premium. This lets you fill specific gaps in your deck without relying entirely on luck, but the cost is steep. The best collections are built through adventure, not commerce.

Cards belong to you. You can trade with other players, sell cards you don't need, or hoard everything. Your collection is your own.

Talk to Each Other

This is a cooperative game. You share a health pool. You share a mana pool. You share a board. Every card you play affects your entire team, and every card your teammates play affects you.

There is no rule that can substitute for communication. If the Alchemist wants to play a high-risk card, the party should agree. If the Hexer wants to exile something the Necromancer is saving, they should talk about it. If the Commander is choosing who gets the buff, the party should discuss priorities.

The best parties aren't the ones with the best cards. They're the ones that talk.